Plan of Research: AI-Mediated Communication in Collective Creative Practice

Whose Contribution Counts? Generative AI, Cultural Participation and Collective Authorship in Research-Creation

Proposed Plan of Study, PhD in Communication & Culture, Fall 2027

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I am an artistic practitioner and researcher working through research-creation, trained in architecture and landscape architecture and now building interactive 3D environments and multiplayer games. My doctoral project asks how generative AI (GenAI), meaning the models, interfaces and platforms that operate them, reorganizes interpretive authority and collective authorship in collaborative artistic practice. When a model turns a participant's words, images or sounds into shared material, whose interpretation becomes visible, whose contribution remains recognizable, who can revise or refuse the transformation, and who is credited or held responsible? These questions reach beyond any one artwork: interpretive authority is concentrating in proprietary platforms, models can standardize culturally situated expression, and a system's record of who supplied what seldom settles credit or responsibility.

My objects of study are collaborative art-making with a limited set of GenAI and non-AI tools, and the artwork it produces. Using the program's research-creation option, the project begins with my own studio inquiry, followed by consultation with four to six practitioners; workshops with about 18–24 adult interdisciplinary artists and community-engaged practitioners in three cohorts, with participant observation; semi-structured focus groups; and the co-creation of a room-scale installation, proposed for exhibition at York, in which revisions, refusals and contested credit remain visible. Analysis combines episode, thematic and version analysis with critical reading of interfaces and platform terms. Participants may refuse GenAI at any point and remain equal collaborators.

The project would contribute a communication-and-culture account of how GenAI redistributes interpretive authority, a research-creation method for studying it, and an artwork that keeps those negotiations open to public encounter. It belongs to Technology in Practice, with Media & Culture as a minor, and to the program's aim of promoting "the application of critical theory and research." I hope to work with Dr. Rebecca Caines, whose research on improvisation as methodology, socially responsive creative technologies and GenAI as a critical improvisation practice grounds this approach.

Each stage of my training asked how designed environments shape the way people perceive and relate to one another. In architecture at Tabriz Islamic Art University (Best Dissertation Award, 2016) and landscape architecture at Istanbul Technical University, where I studied perception of mediated environments (eCAADe 2023), I designed space as a medium of social life, where thresholds and paths decide who gathers and is seen. At Simon Fraser University's iViz Lab, my thesis asked what happens when a technical system translates an ambiguous human state into a shared representation. I built a networked Unity game that rendered teammates' heart rate as an ambient cue (accepted at ACM ISS 2026) and a world whose fog and light responded to the player. Participants accepted visibility only when it was optional and asked to control who could see it. The PhD extends that question from bodily signals to cultural production.